

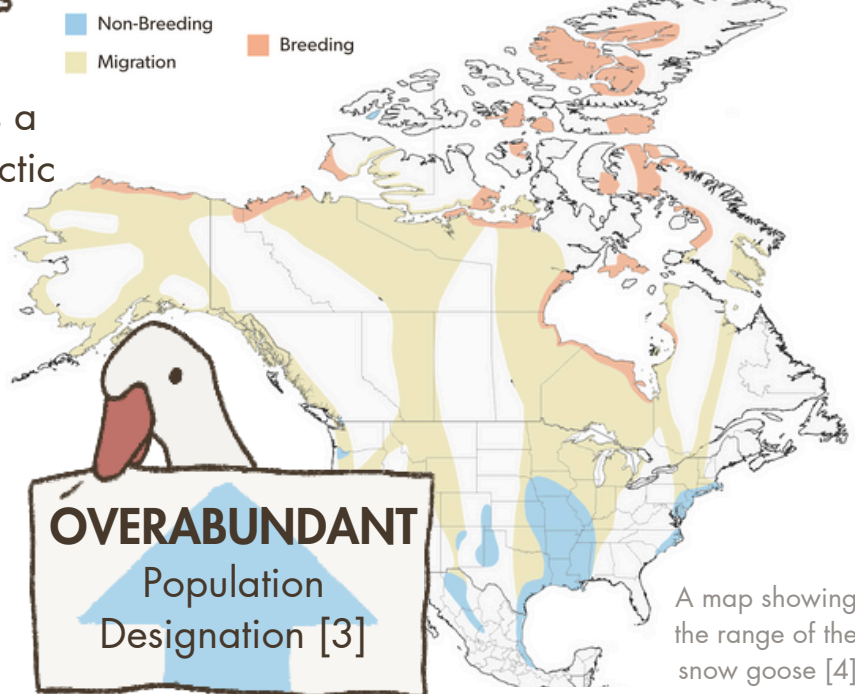
THE GEESE ARE TAKING OVER: ARCTIC SHOREBIRD POPULATION DECLINES

Theodora Amie Ghosh

Meet the Goose

Anser caerulescens, the snow goose, is a migratory species that nests in the subarctic and arctic regions of Canada [1].

Mostly Herbivorous [2]



Anser caerulescens (snow goose) [5]

Meet the Shorebird

Pluvialis dominica, the American golden-plover, is one of many shorebird species that nest in the same regions as the snow goose [6].

> 50%
Population Decrease
Since 1970 [7]

Mostly
Carnivorous [8]



Pluvialis dominica (American golden-plover) [9]

Why Are There So Many Geese?

For decades, spilled grain from harvesting machinery in the United States and Canada has been bolstering the herbivorous snow goose populations during their migration to the arctic [1].



John Deere Combine Harvester [10]

Dynamics of Arctic Ecosystems

Geese and shorebirds share predators in their arctic nesting grounds [11].



Stercorarius parasiticus (parasitic jaeger) [12]



Vulpes lagopus (arctic fox) [13]

An increase in the snow goose population causes predators to become more active around the colony, threatening the eggs of shorebirds [14].

Snow geese also leave less vegetation for shorebirds to conceal their nests with, making them more vulnerable [15].



The loss of shorebirds disrupts the tundra food web, altering marine and terrestrial nutrient cycling, and slow growing conditions make recovery difficult [1].

What Can We Do About It?

WHAT THE GOVERNMENT IS DOING:

The Canadian Wildlife Service, alongside the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, have issued new rules to hunters regarding snow geese, to encourage harvesting of overabundant populations [1].

WE CAN:



Learn about arctic shorebirds and the habitat they depend on [14]



Donate to conservation groups that work to preserve that habitat [7]



Raise awareness in our communities about hunting regulations [1]



Invest in agricultural machinery that causes less spillage [1]

REFERENCES:

Illustrations [17]



Icons [16]

